

Stratus readies XA2000 series to take on Tandem high end

BY JAMES CONNOLLY
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MARLBORO, Mass. — Stratus Computer, Inc. is scheduled to launch a full-scale attack on its chief rival in the transaction processing market, Tandem Computers, Inc., with the introduction of a new line of systems today.

Stratus, which previously offered fault-tolerant systems competing with the lower half of Tandem's product line, is pitting the high end of its XA2000 series against Tandem's 10-month-old premier Non-Stop VLX processor. Both companies claim peak performance rates of more than 50 transaction/sec.

Stratus officials said they anticipate a near-simultaneous announcement this week from IBM, which sells Stratus-built processors as the IBM System/88 and is expected to add the XA2000 machines to the System/88 product line.

"We are selling into a market that has an insatiable appetite for transactions per second," Stra-

tus Chief Executive Officer William E. Foster said.

"Most new applications for computers tend to be on-line applications. That is really what is driving the market. While people are looking at an on-line application, they have to ask themselves what happens if this thing goes down," Foster said.

Designed for growth

Stratus claimed its systems are designed to cope with 45% annual growth rates in the on-line transaction processing market for the next five years to average transaction loads of more than 50 transaction/sec. and the addition of more on-line applications.

Company officials cited the XA2000's capability to be expanded in a modular, on-line manner and the fact that it is designed to handle more powerful microprocessors as they are announced.

Like earlier Stratus systems, the XA2000 is designed for fault tolerance through use of duplicated hardware with a backup

processor board, disk drive or other component picking up the processing if a component fails.

Stratus is announcing five models of the XA2000 series, although the XA2000 Model 100 is a transition product providing performance comparable to that

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of the older Stratus XA400.

The systems are based on Motorola, Inc. 16-MHz 68020 microprocessors and Motorola 68881 math coprocessors. Earlier Stratus systems used Motorola 68010 chips.

The XA2000 systems use a different chassis than the XA400

but similar enclosures. Stratus officials said the XA2000 Models 110, 120, 130 and 140 use a single 40-slot chassis and that upgrades from the 110 through the 140 are achieved through on-line board additions.

The Model 140 runs four tightly coupled duplicated CPUs.

Operating system

Stratus also is enhancing its operating system with VOS Release 6.0, which was designed to take advantage of the hardware changes, including a 32-bit data path and the math coprocessor.

Peter S. Kastner, manager of marketing support programs for Stratus, said the floating-point processor is designed to help users in existing on-line transaction processing markets perform tasks such as financial modeling. He said the company has no plans to use the 68881 capability to enter scientific or engineering markets.

The XA2000 reportedly supports 64M bytes of memory, a 64K-byte cache, a virtual address space of 128M bytes and 46G bytes of disk storage.

Stratus officials said the Model 140 provides three times the performance of the earlier Stratus XA600 using the ET-1 benchmark and 2½ times the XA600's power using Stratus's

TP-1 benchmark.

Stratus claimed the transaction-per-second cost of the XA2000 is half that of Stratus's earlier products.

In addition, Stratus claimed ET-1 ratings of 15 transaction/sec. for the Model 110, 27 to 29 transaction/sec. for the Model 120, 37 to 40 transaction/sec. for the Model 130 and 47 to 53 transaction/sec. for the Model 140.

Analyst Thomas Henkel of the Yankee Group, a Boston-based market research firm, said of Stratus, "This is really the first time they have gotten into the VLX or IBM 3090 class in terms of on-line transaction performance, and I think it is a good move for them."

However, Henkel also questioned how long IBM will maintain its relationship with Stratus if the smaller company's products continue to compete with 3090 mainframes.

He said he doubts Stratus has enough application and data base software to support high-performance transaction processing, particularly in growth areas such as manufacturing.

Available now, the systems are priced from \$260,000 to \$500,000 for the Model 110 and from \$770,000 to \$1.1 million for the Model 140.